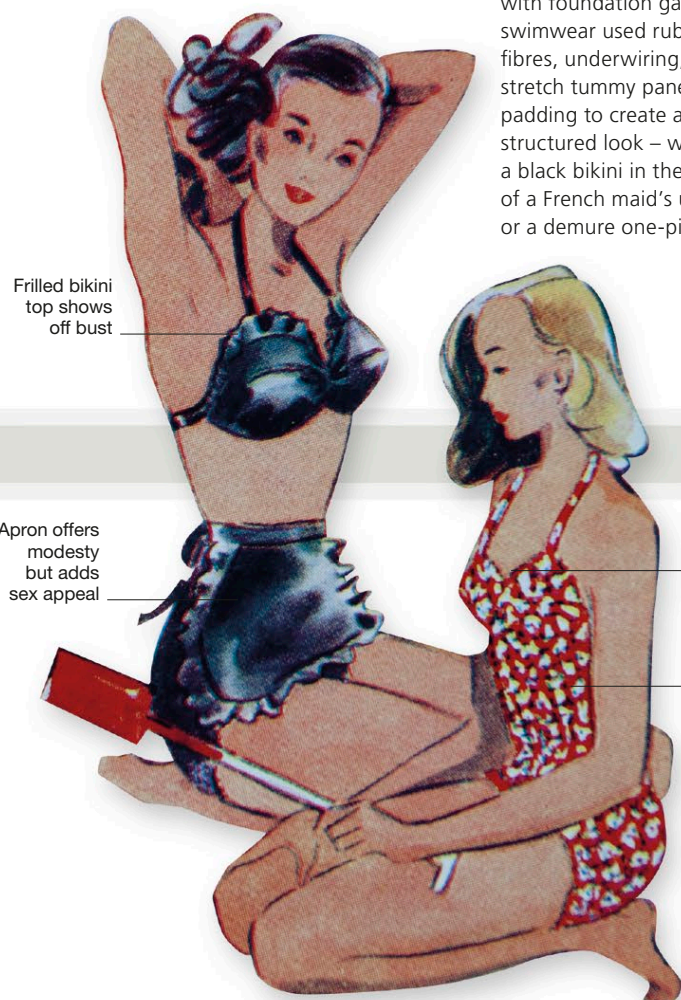


Hourglass silhouette As with foundation garments, swimwear used rubber elastic fibres, underwiring, boning, stretch tummy panels, and padding to create a smooth, structured look – whether a black bikini in the guise of a French maid’s uniform, or a demure one-piece.



Frilled bikini top shows off bust

Apron offers modesty but adds sex appeal

Exaggerated ruffles for fun

Classic sweetheart neckline

Smooth lines thanks to new rubber technology

Girl’s one-piece Surface textures and effects were popular in the 1950s, thanks to new manufacturing processes and affordable synthetic fabrics. Ruffles and shirring transform this child’s swimsuit into a special garment.

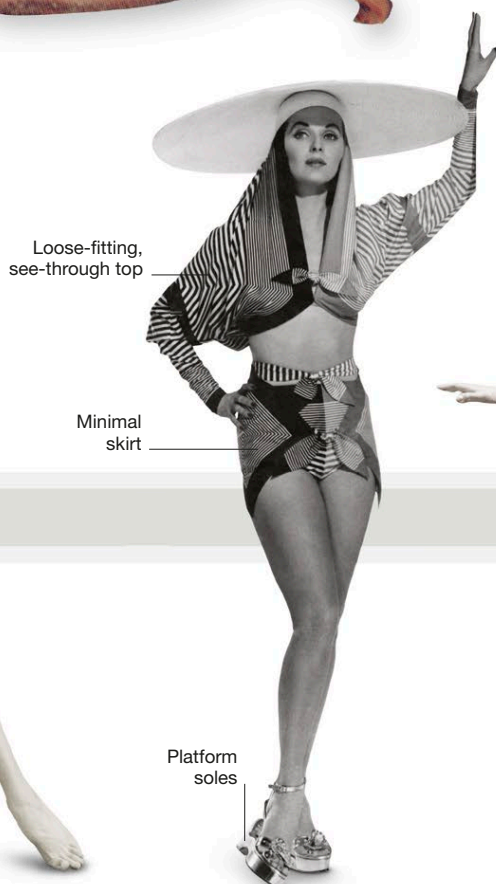


Halter-tie neckline common for swimwear

Shirred midriff creates shape



Bold pattern



Loose-fitting, see-through top

Minimal skirt

Platform soles



Plaits, for girlish effect

More natural bustline

Form-fitting capri pants

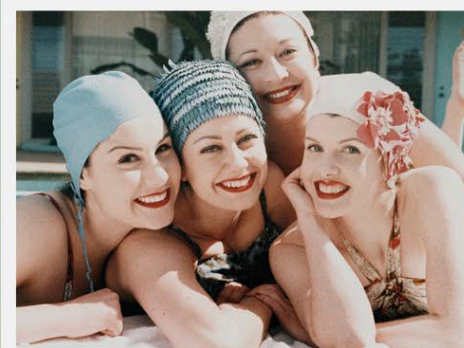
Casual ballet flats

Hooded top Then, as now, summer weather was unpredictable. This hooded beach top from the mid-1950s provided a quick cover-up for swimmers and sunbathers if the weather turned chilly.

Head-turning Confidence would have been needed to parade on the beach in this striking outfit, modelled in 1952. Both the top and the tiny matching skirt, worn over a bikini, are see-through.

All about sex By 1961, when this photo of Brigitte Bardot was taken, resort clothes were more relaxed. The emphasis was now on youthfulness, freedom, and raw sex appeal.

ACCESSORIES



Maintaining a polished appearance was a priority for the 1950s woman, so fashion companies produced resort accessories. For sunseekers there were cover-ups, costume jewellery, raffia, straw and cotton beach bags, hats, shoes, and sunglasses to coordinate with their outfits. Because hairdos were carefully coiffed, a bathing cap was de rigueur; designers had fun with it, turning a mundane piece of sports kit into a decorative display adorned with rubber petals, spikes, scalloping, and ruffles.



Peach sunglasses



Sunflower sunglasses



Peep-toe mule

Out of the water, women wore large straw hats, especially lampshade styles, often decorated with embroidered raffia flowers and fruit. Sunglasses had been mass-produced since the late 1920s, but after World War II, when UV technology improved and air force pilots made the aviator style sexy, they were sold in a variety of novel shapes. Pointed and winged frames were especially popular. When it came to footwear, there were espadrilles (part of a craze for all things Spanish), Japanese-style wooden slides, carved mules inspired by Polynesian crafts, and rubber flip-flops, which really took off after the Korean War when returning soldiers brought them back as souvenirs.